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## Contents


[English text unavailable] . . . . . 2
[English text unavailable] . . . . . 4
[English text unavailable] . . . . . 8
[English text unavailable] . . . . . 10
[English text unavailable] . . . . . 11
[English text unavailable] . . . . . 15
[English text unavailable] . . . . . 19
[English text unavailable] . . . . . 20
[English text unavailable] . . . . . 22
[English text unavailable] . . . . . 22
[English text unavailable] . . . . . 26

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COL-312701

On the Inside

Hohes Schloss

Marsha: I, Marsha, before my brethren of the Order, do solemnly take this oath.

Marsha: I vow loyalty and obedience, to renounce all possessions, to care for my brethren, and never to forsake the Order.

Marsha: I vow to hold the Hochland Order in reverence, to defend it faithfully, and to fulfill my duties with unwavering devotion.

Marsha: I vow to keep this oath without deceit, to heed the statutes of virtue, and to honor the counsel of my brethren—

Marsha: Until the day of my death.

A hand rests on her shoulder, bringing with it the weight of enormous responsibilities.

Grand Master of the Order: In the name of our sacred Order and with the blessings of the Lord above, we accept your oath.

Grand Master of the Order: We bestow upon you these gifts: bread, pure water, and your robes.

She puts her hands together and allows the heavy cloak to settle on her shoulders.

Another weight shifts onto the cloak, a hand.

???: From today onwards, you walk the path of a knight.

???: You will learn that it is as much a burden as an honor, Marsha ...

Marsha: I understand.

She clutches her hands together, feeling the warm moisture on her palms.

Fallback Position, The Foundation

The knight folds her hands once more.

A rare peace settles over the safe zone, yet it does little to soothe the dead and dying.

Marsha: Brothers and sisters, you have proven your courage this day. Do not fear the darkness; I shall pray for you ...

Marsha: May you rest in peace and in the light.

She finishes her prayer and opens her eyes, composing herself once more.

Since their long retreat, they've been forced to tend to the heavily wounded on the move, but for every soldier they save, another succumbs to infection.

Field Nurse: So many lives lost needlessly, if only we had proper facilities or just clean bandages ...

She lets out a heavy sigh. Marsha moves to comfort her.

Marsha: We've done all that we could, Marguerite.

Marsha: Every life is precious, but it is not in our hands to decide who lives and who dies.

Messenger: Sister Marsha, Commander Creius is asking for you.

Marsha: I'm on my way.

Marsha looks over the dressing station once more before she leaves.

Marsha: Commander Creius ...

Creius: I've received a report from "Razor" Squad. They say they've encountered a Hochland Knight in Sen, not far from the frontlines.

Marsha: ...!

Marsha: Someone from my Order?

Creius: It seems so. "Razor" has attempted contact, but she made it clear she has no intention of evacuating.

Creius: I need you to go to Sen and find out what's going on.

Creius: We've temporarily put Manus Vindictae on the back foot, but it's only a matter of time until they come back in force. We can't have these sorts of loose ends blunting our efforts.

Creius: I do believe you may be able to bridge the gap between the Foundation and your former comrade.

Marsha: I'll do all that I can.

Marsha: But, the dressing station ...

Creius: We're moving as many of the wounded as we can to the rear tomorrow.

Creius: To real hospitals. They'll see proper care.

Creius: There's a train to Sen in two hours. You're to leave as soon as possible.

Marsha: Understood, sir.

The knight touches her pauldrons as she leaves the office.

Marsha: It's been so long ...

She feels a wave of relief, but it's soon tinged with anxiety.

Train Station, Sen

The train pulls into the station with a long whistle.

Marsha feels the tension in her neck relax a little as she steps off with the rest of the crowd.

"Razor" Captain: Marsha, you're finally here.

"Razor" stands waiting for Marsha at the station, a look of pained helplessness is written across his face.

Marsha: Mr. Razor, please inform me of the situation in full.

"Razor" Captain: You were told about the knight that has refused to speak with us, correct?

"Razor" Captain: Well, there's another problem; we've gotten word of extensive movement from Manus Vindictae in the region. An offensive, perhaps, or at the very least a sizeable troop redeployment.

"Razor" Captain: Our orders are to clear the area of all civilians, but your old comrade ...

"Razor" Captain: She refuses to budge.

He shakes his head begrudgingly.

Marsha: She won't evacuate? Do you have any idea why?

"Razor" Captain: ... I think that's something only you can figure out.

"Razor" Captain: But if her replies are any indication, she seems intent on fighting Manus Vindictae.

Marsha: By herself? That seems entirely unreasonable.

"Razor" Captain: Now you see why we wanted you.

"Razor" Captain: We know that the Knights of the Hochland Order are powerful. You're living proof of their capabilities.

"Razor" Captain: But we can't just let her charge out alone against the Manus. It'll put our operations here at risk.

"Razor" Captain: And we don't want unnecessary bloodshed.

Marsha: Our vows are a sacred commitment; it's little wonder she would want to fight. Still, I don't understand why someone from my Order would refuse to cooperate.

Marsha: There must be some reason she is being so stubborn. I wonder what she is after ...

Marsha keeps that question in mind as she takes her leave from "Razor" and walks from the station into the city.

# [English text unavailable]

COL-312702

Where We Stand Now

Sen

Sen has already seen the full brunt of arcane warfare, their aftereffects turning the streets into a twisted mockery of their former existence.

But the Foundation succeeded in getting most of the population out before the fighting got too close, leaving the area like a strange lifeless moonscape.

Marsha: According to Mr. Razor, the knight should be somewhere around here ...

Marsha stands at the crossroads, taking stock of her surroundings.

Closed doors, dark storefronts, occasionally life stirs in the form of passing refugees trudging their most treasured possessions toward the evacuation points.

Marsha: ... Has she already left?

Woman: Staś! Wait!

The shout comes from the end of the street, Marsha turns alert and ready for danger.

But no sooner does she turn than a tiny form slams into her leg.

Boy: Watch it, lady! Don't you know there's a war coming?

The boy tumbles out onto the street, along with his felt hat and everything he's holding.

Marsha: Entschuldigung (excuse me). Is everything alright, young man?

Marsha: Are you hurt at all?

Marsha crouches down to inspect the boy.

Boy: Leave me alone. Mama is going to catch me—

The boy gathers his things in a rush.

Marsha: Hold on!

She grabs the boy just as he is about to run, nearly causing him to stumble again.

His mother runs toward them, out of breath.

Marsha: Staś ... Can I call you that? What happened? Why are you running around out here?

Marsha: This place isn't safe. You should go home to your mother.

The boy twists with all his strength to break free from Marsha, his thin face flushing.

Seeing that he can't escape, his shoulders slump in frustration.

Boy: I-I just want to deliver a gift!

Marsha: A gift?

Woman: Phew ... You little brat!

The boy's mother at last catches up, puffing with both exasperation and exhaustion, and gives his head a smack.

Woman: Thank you so much, madam. I swear I look away for just one second and he starts charging into trouble.

Boy: I wasn't charging into trouble! I had to deliver my gift! You always tell me to keep my word, well, that's what I'm doing!

Woman: There's no time for that. What if we miss the evacuation train?

The boy pouts, but he has no argument.

Marsha: Would you let me know what's going on here? Please, don't worry. I'm on a mission from the St. Pavlov Foundation.

Marsha points to the badge on her chest.

Marsha: If it's something as simple as delivering a gift, perhaps I can help?

Boy: Really?!

The boy wrings himself free and offers Marsha the item he had been carrying.

Marsha: Is this ... a shield?

The construction is somewhat rudimentary, made of welded steel with an old belt for a strap, and it's on the smaller side, only as long as her forearm, but its purpose is unmistakable.

Red paint twists into a shape across its rough surface; it's difficult to make sense of, but it seems to portray the silhouette of a building on a hill.

Woman: My little Staś had a bad fever. With the way things were, we were worried we wouldn't be able to get him to a doctor. But then we came across this woman.

Woman: Oh, she was wearing armor just like yours.

The woman points toward Marsha's pauldrons, a bit surprised.

Woman: She healed Staś, and to repay her kindness, he wanted to give her a shield to match her armor.

Woman: My husband ... he helped him make it from an old bucket.

Woman: With the evacuation order and all the packing, we haven't had time to give it to her. I put it away for later.

Woman: But then Staś happened to find it, and ... since then, I haven't had a moment's peace.

Marsha: ... The sigil on the shield, is it meant to be a castle on a hill?

Woman: That's right. Are you ...

Marsha: Yes. A fellow member of her Order. I'm looking for her.

Marsha: Have you any idea where she is, and ... did you happen to get her name?

Within an old but tidy house, a kettle begins to roll and cry with steam.

A woman in knightly armor sits on a wooden chair, cleaning her helmet with care.

It bears the scratches and scuffs of untold numbers of battles, yet it has clearly been meticulously maintained.

A knock at the door breaks the rhythm of her work.

???: Who is it?

Marsha: Sister Adelheid? Are you in there?

The sound is soft and faint, filtered by the door, but Adelheid feels her heart skip.

Marsha: It's me, Marsha.

Adelheid: ...!

It's a voice she could never mistake.

Her palms feel numb as she moves toward the door; she almost involuntarily jerks it open.

The face she sees behind the door is both everything she feared and hoped for.

A face she once thought gone and buried. A face that elicits grief and sorrow in every reflection. But now all she feels is joy.

Marsha: Adelheid. It's really you ... I'm so glad.

The woman in front of her is tired—maybe from a long journey—but breathing, radiating warmth.

Not a skeleton, not some revenant or nightmare.

Living, breathing, at her doorstep.

Adelheid: It's a miracle! Marsha, you're here! You're alive.

She nearly leaps toward her, her hands stretch outward, but she freezes in place from shock or awe or fear—she can't say.

Yet Marsha reaches in and pulls her into a warm embrace.

Marsha: Yes, Adelheid, I survived "Dead Man's Hill."

Marsha: I'm so glad you did as well.

It is a true blessing, being able to reunite in these times of war.

Adelheid lets out a long-drawn breath and nestles into the hug, before breaking from it with a reassuring pat.

Adelheid: Come inside. The winter has come early this year; I'd rather not let the chill in.

Marsha: I have something for you, a gift of thanks from Staś.

The rough shield is delivered to the knight as promised. Adelheid takes it and turns it in her hands.

Adelheid: I will have to give him a proper thank you, should we ever chance to meet again. His family has done me a great service; they helped me find this place.

Adelheid: But Marsha, I must know ... How did you manage to survive?

The question is asked alongside an offered cup of tea. The curling steam masks the betrayal at the heart of her answer.

Marsha: I was injured during the fight. When I went down, I thought perhaps I would die. But my armor had saved me from the worst of the damage. I used my training and waited.

Marsha: I just lay still, sealing away every thought and pain in my body until a medical team from the Foundation discovered me.

Marsha: I recovered under their care.

Adelheid: But your armor ...

Marsha: This was all that was salvageable after the medics cut me free. But I could never fully part with it.

Marsha: Not that it matters much. Armor is more of a hindrance than an aid on the battlefield now.

Adelheid: ... We have always clung to our traditions, perhaps even after they were no longer of use.

She studies Marsha as she speaks, taking note of her uniform beneath the pauldrons. No longer a knight, but not a soldier either, a nurse's frock.

And on this new uniform, an unexpected badge, one she immediately recognizes with a stir of aversion.

Marsha: Adelheid, why are you out here alone? Where are the other members of our Order?

Adelheid takes a long sip of her tea, as if trying to swallow down questions she hasn't yet found the courage to ask.

Adelheid: ... A lot has happened in the Order.

Adelheid: I suppose, first of all, that I am now its acting Grand Master.

Marsha: ...!

In the event of the Grand Master's death, the role is passed to the knight with the highest seniority until a new leader is confirmed.

Neither needs to remind the other of this plain fact.

Marsha: What happened to Master Hermann?

Adelheid: It is as you fear; he's dead.

Marsha can't help but draw a sharp breath.

Marsha: ... How? When did it happen?

Adelheid: Less than a month ago.

Marsha: I heard nothing about it ...

Adelheid: Surely you know that Manus Vindictae rose out from the shadows, that they've unleashed this war on all of humanity rather than face the consequences of their manipulation.

Adelheid: But their earlier infiltration was deeper even than anyone had known. Every communication network has been compromised or crippled. Including ours.

Adelheid: You have been away from the Order for too long. It's only natural that you wouldn't know.

Marsha tightens her grip on the cup; there's a needle-like accusation in her words.

Master Hermann had led for more than a decade.

Though as a young novice and later knight, she had little direct contact with him.

But she knew, as all young knights of the Order did, that Hermann was a model of chivalry: brave, loyal, strict, and maybe a little too rigid, but a man worth looking up to.

Marsha: ... How did he die?

The idea that a man of such virtue and wisdom was gone, that he had fallen in some godforsaken battlefield, twists in her heart.

Adelheid: He was killed in our very castle ... Whoever did it framed things to look like a suicide, but I saw the scene with my own eyes. There was a struggle in that room.

Adelheid: Yet, the Order was under pressure from the government; the others decided to brush the investigation under the rug rather than face the possibility that we had been compromised like the army.

Adelheid: I went through his letters and diaries. He already noticed the shadows of Manus Vindictae operating in our ranks.

Marsha: ... Master Hermann was loyal to his oaths and to us. He must have been attempting to expose them.

Adelheid: But even so, once the military's involvement with the Manus was revealed, things started to fall apart.

Adelheid: There was only one thing that all of us realized—

Adelheid: We had been betrayed.

Marsha: ...

Adelheid: With the armistice coming, we withdrew from fighting to determine what to do next.

Adelheid: But even as we left the front, the divisions began to show. Some wanted to return to Hohes Schloss and build it into an independent state. To carve out our own personal kingdom as it was in the ancient past.

Marsha: Had they learned nothing from the war? How were mounted knights supposed to rule in a time of machine guns and tanks?

Adelheid: I think they understood the futility; maybe they even realized how foolish they were being. But when all else falls apart, people often turn to nostalgia and tradition. They faced into the bleak future and chose to believe in an idyllic past.

Adelheid: But there is a greater tragedy. Manus Vindictae had beaten the main force home. They ransacked the castle, killed its defenders, and left it in ruins.

Adelheid puts down her cup. Its bottom clinks as it hits the table.

Adelheid: Centuries of wealth accumulated by our Order and all the rewards of its glory were gone.

Adelheid: Our treasures are doubtless being melted down to fuel their schemes.

Marsha closes her eyes.

She knows every room, every corridor, every pillar of that castle.

It was her home.

She imagines all those familiar things being torn down, stripped, sold for parts, and melted into scrap. A firestorm of anger and humiliation wells up inside her, but years of training kick in, and she calms herself with her arcane skill.

Marsha: ... I hope the castle itself will be restored.

The emotions fall away, and reason takes over; something clicks in her mind.

Marsha: Is that why you haven't left this place?

Adelheid's lips curve.

Adelheid: Ach so, then you have come to me on behalf of your Foundation.

# [English text unavailable]

COL-312703

The First Lesson

Marsha falls silent.

She looks at Adelheid, and Adelheid looks back—measuring her.

Marsha: ... I won't deny that I was sent here by them.

Adelheid: Then at the very least you have not sacrificed your honesty along with the rest of your sacred vows.

Marsha: I would never lie to or deceive another of our Order. Least of all you.

Marsha: But ... there's no contradiction between my mission and my loyalty to you.

Marsha: Adelheid, you raised me; the Order gave me a home and a purpose.

Marsha: I will always care for you—and the safety of our people.

She chooses each word carefully but sincerely.

Her mentor holds a long silence, leaving only the sound of the windows rattling in the wind. At last, she breaks the quiet with intention.

Adelheid: In two days, a convoy from Manus Vindictae will pass through Rejowa, carrying all that they've stolen from us.

Adelheid: As acting Grand Master, I cannot allow them to escape with their plunder—not after failing to prevent their raid in the first place.

Adelheid: I will not allow this opportunity to pass untaken.

Marsha: But Manus Vindictae has weapons enhanced with arcane skills. You're only one knight. You can't do this alone. The danger is too great.

Marsha: Maybe you can work something out with the Foundation so that—

Adelheid: "Danger."

Adelheid repeats the word under her breath like a rebuke.

Adelheid: They killed Master Hermann and violated the sanctity of our home. If our vows mean anything at all, I must answer these transgressions. To leave without avenging it ...

Adelheid: This is the gravest danger a knight has ever faced!

Adelheid: The Order may be much diminished, but we are not so base as to ask bureaucrats to fight our battles.

Adelheid's words land with weight.

Her expression is cold and point-of-fact. The warmth and joy she had shown to Marsha is gone.

Now, she speaks to her as she would, and certainly has, to any other St. Pavlov Foundation employee.

Marsha: ... I'm sorry. I shouldn't have brought it up.

The pale sunlight outside the window cuts deep shadows across Adelheid's face.

But then Marsha notices something in that cold detachment and pulls her friend's closed fist into her hands.

Adelheid: Marsha ...

Anger, sadness, and disappointment begin to pass through their interlaced fingers into the young knight.

The older woman exhales, relieved. Her emotions, too long dammed up, are now passed into another's hand.

# [English text unavailable]

COL-312704

Marsha: You've borne this weight too long, Adelheid.

Marsha: We are sworn to carry each other's burdens. You may doubt me, but I have not forgotten my vows. Those words made us sisters, and I will never forsake that bond.

She can feel Adelheid's emotions spin over the words; a rush of anger, pain, and sorrow floods between them.

Adelheid: You say you remember our teachings. Do you not remember the danger in taking in another's emotions?

Adelheid: It is a last resort, one used only in times of great peril. Did I fail to impress that lesson on you too?

Marsha smiles—feeling like that clueless young novice she once was. With a rush of embarrassment, then guilt, but also affection.

Marsha: You taught me to put the needs of my comrades above all other things; that includes sharing their pain and their duty.

Marsha: So, allow me to fight with you. If we stand together, we may stand a chance at succeeding.

Marsha: I won't leave you to fight this battle alone, sister.

Adelheid: ... I don't presume to think I could tell you no. You've never listened to a word I've said.

Marsha looks up at her mentor, feeling a hot flush of pride pass through her.

Adelheid: We leave at dawn.

Outside Hohes Schloss

The crashing of the waves on the rocky shore does its best to drown out the little whimpers below.

Adelheid: I knew I'd find you here, Marsha.

The young girl looks up, her face streaked with tears.

Adelheid: It was the other novices again, wasn't it?

Marsha wipes her tears with her sleeve, but the spray of seawater has left her robes too damp to dry her face.

Marsha: ... What should I do, master?

Adelheid lowers herself to the rocky precipice along with her.

Adelheid: What do you think you should do, Sister Marsha?

Marsha: I-I tried to leave them alone and just do what I'm told, but—

Adelheid: No.

A warm, broad hand brushes the girl's tears. She looks up at her caretaker, confused.

Adelheid: They upset you because you allowed them. You showed them fear, and they seized on it.

Adelheid: Wolves do not strike a standing deer. The hunt begins only after they put them to flight.

Marsha: Then ...

Adelheid: Be as a stag in the forest. When they push you, show no fear, turn your antlers on them. Fight back.

Marsha: But they're taller than me ... and stronger ...

Adelheid: Strength will come as you train. Height too, so long as you remember to eat your vegetables.

Adelheid: You must show them that you won't run.

Adelheid: They may howl and bark; you may even lose a few battles—but you must show them above all else ...

Adelheid: That you have the courage to fight back.

Adelheid: You are to be a knight, Sister Marsha. A true knight does not falter, nor does she pout.

Adelheid offers a reassuring pat on the young girl's shoulder.

Marsha: I know. I want to become a true knight, brave and strong ...

She says the words with both innocence and ambition.

The waves crash against the rocks again like the drumming of a coming battle.

Marsha opens her eyes. In the dark room, the only thing she can see is the faint metallic shimmer of light glinting off of her pauldrons.

Adelheid: Good, I don't need to wake you.

By the window, Adelheid is already packing. Staś's shield is fastened at her waist.

Marsha lets out a long breath.

Marsha: Please wait, Adelheid. I'll be ready in a minute.

Soon, Marsha shoulders her first-aid crate and heads out with Adelheid.

# [English text unavailable]

COL-312705

The Second Lesson

Rejowa

The two knights begin their journey across the war-torn countryside and reach Rejowa by nightfall.

They stop at the outskirts of the town, already dilapidated before the war, a maze of husked-out ruins and empty buildings.

Adelheid: Their convoy should pass through here this time tomorrow.

Adelheid: The roads narrow here before passing through the town center; it will force them to slow and move in single file. This is where we launch our attack.

Adelheid surveys their surroundings and points to the only path leading through the town.

Marsha: The houses here are all abandoned. Most left in a hurry; there should still be some things left behind.

Marsha: We can borrow this house for the night.

Marsha walks to the back of the house and examines it carefully.

Under the eaves, strings of dried nettle and yarrow sway in the wind. Marsha touches them, sweeping the dust away.

Adelheid: Has your Foundation given you leave to come along with me?

Marsha: I've reported back to my commander and to Mr. Razor. At any rate, my task was to convince you to leave Sen; I would say this is an interpretation of those orders.

She doesn't respond. The brisk wind passing through the old town rises to fill the void.

Adelheid: ... Marsha, I'm truly glad you survived.

Adelheid: But I still don't understand your decision. Why didn't you ever attempt to contact us? Why would you want to leave our Order?

I shall never forsake the Order, nor shall I hold fealty to another—Marsha had made these solemn oaths the day she became a knight.

She had been waiting for these questions, accusations even, but when they arrived, she found that Adelheid's tone was far gentler than she expected.

Marsha: ... I could not bear to take another soldier's life.

Marsha: The path of knighthood should not be one of endless slaughter on the battlefield.

Marsha: If I returned to the Order, if I had stayed a knight. I would have been forced to fight, kill, and die.

Absolute loyalty to the Order and unquestioning obedience to its authority. That was the demand made on all those who swore its oath.

And one of the few she ever doubted.

Adelheid: I've dealt with this "Foundation" of yours before. I admit their intentions seem noble, and they have done some good. Yet, I also know they've been recruiting soldiers and amassing military strength.

Adelheid: Your Foundation will soon command an army, moving between countries and acting according to their own authority. An organization with no oversight and no accountability.

Adelheid: In many ways they are as dangerous as Manus Vindictae.

Marsha: ... I agree entirely.

Marsha: But I have chosen to put my faith in them, in what my own eyes have seen of their work.

Marsha: And with the Foundation, I'm free to do the work that I believe in. To save lives, not end them.

Marsha: I can do so much more good with them than I ever could before.

Her mentor shakes her head ruefully.

Adelheid: What you've done is without precedent in our Order.

Marsha: I understand.

Marsha doesn't rush to persuade her. She only focuses on what would matter most to her.

Marsha: I never truly abandoned my vows as a knight.

Marsha: And worry for the sake of the Order ...

Marsha: What are you going to do, Master?

The woman pauses, composing her thoughts and vision for the future.

Adelheid: After I reclaim our treasured relics and return them, I will begin a search for all our scattered knights.

Adelheid: I don't know what comes after that. I will allow our future to unwind as it will.

Adelheid: Though I'm certain it does not include setting up our own feudal state out of an old castle.

Marsha notices the confusion in Adelheid's words.

Marsha: Grand Master, may I share my thoughts with you?

Adelheid: Yes?

Marsha: I want to rebuild the Hochland Order as a humanitarian medical relief organization.

Marsha: That way, our knights can be freed from further bloodshed and return to the Order's greater purpose.

She gives weight to the young knight's words, whether out of respect or genuine consideration.

Adelheid: ... That is not who we are, Sister.

Marsha had expected her mentor's reluctance, but she purses her lips and doesn't back down.

Marsha: Adelheid, please consider the possibilities. I have given this a great deal of thought.

Marsha: Since joining the Foundation and assisting people as a medic and a nurse, I've had a chance to reflect on the things you've taught me.

Marsha: You told me yourself that our Order was founded as a place of healing for wounded soldiers and victims of war. Couldn't that be true again?

Adelheid goes blank. That familiar look of forcefully suppressed emotion crosses her face. Then she simply turns and walks into a nearby house.

Adelheid: It's late. We need to rest.

Marsha remains outside the door and lifts her gaze.

Low clouds drift overhead like the palm of a giant, ready to close in, offering no escape.

Marsha: *sigh*

Marsha limps into the castle. Her figure looks small beneath the towering columns.

A shadow falls over her, swallowing her entirely.

Marsha: Adelheid?

The knight wears a stern expression. She seems to have been waiting for some time.

Adelheid: I watched your training today. You were ordered to fall back, yet you chose to stay behind and hold off the pursuers.

Marsha: Yes, ma'am.

Adelheid: What was your reason?

Marsha: There were wounded. Someone had to buy them time, or the whole team might have been caught.

Adelheid: And you believed your sacrifice would guarantee their escape—mission accomplished. Is that correct?

Marsha: ... Yes, ma'am.

Adelheid: And did you buy them enough time?

Marsha: ... No, ma'am. After I "died," the pursuers caught up with the rest of the team.

Her "heroic sacrifice" ended prematurely; tapped by a blunted spear, she was declared "dead" and put out of the fight.

Adelheid: You stayed behind alone without any cover, without a plan; all you ended up doing was throwing your life away.

The young knight is struck by her master's criticism, but she steels herself and defends her choice.

Marsha: The problem was our choice of evacuation route.

Marsha: If we had attempted the other mountain pass, where the path was narrow, I would have been able to buy them enough time.

Marsha: A knight—a true knight ... is never afraid of death in the service of duty.

She looks up at Adelheid, staring straight into her eyes, her lips pressed into a hard line.

Adelheid: ... And if there is no narrow pass next time? What if you cannot guarantee your sacrifice will mean anything at all?

Adelheid: Do you think I don't know you, child? It wouldn't have made a difference.

Adelheid: You've always acted recklessly.

Adelheid: You volunteered to man the battering ram without even knowing how it works. You're the first to the front in every shield wall and the first to leap into every fight.

Adelheid: I've been too effective, I fear. I turned a scared little girl into a would-be martyr.

Her tone is self-critical, but she softens as she leans toward Marsha.

Adelheid: I know you're eager to prove yourself ... You want to show you're worthy of our vows with some great act of sacrifice.

Adelheid: You want people to forget that you're just some lost orphan discarded in the snow.

Adelheid: That you are, instead, a valiant knight, a fighter worth celebrating through the ages. Isn't that right, Marsha?

Marsha freezes, her face flushing hot. Her deepest desire has been laid bare with complete precision.

Marsha: I ... yes, it's true.

Adelheid: You've replaced your fear with bravado. But you haven't learned to use your courage effectively. Making you foolhardy.

Adelheid turns and motions for Marsha to follow.

Marsha: Where are we going?

Their footsteps echo through the empty hallway, time seeming to slip away in the rhythmic echoes.

Adelheid: A new lesson—something just as important as bravery.

Marsha: Yes?

Adelheid: To cherish your life.

Adelheid: Recklessness doesn't just waste your courage; it puts your comrades in danger as well.

Adelheid: Marsha, do you know why the Hochland Order was founded?

Marsha: You've told me before. It was created to tend to wounded soldiers.

Adelheid: I think it's time I teach you its history in detail.

Adelheid stops and opens the library door behind them.

The night is dark; not a single light nor star illuminates the space beyond her view. Marsha listens to the rustling that pulled her from her sleep.

Someone has slipped inside in the middle of the night and is rummaging around for something.

All but invisible in the darkness, she can spy Adelheid stirring awake. Without exchanging a word, they both continue to feign sleep, waiting for the intruders to come closer.

???: ... Damn it. Nothing here ...

???: Shh, don't wake them up!

The low whispers come from two men.

They creep toward the cabinet above the knights' heads.

Maybe that's what they're after.

???: If it's not here, we have to get back—

???: Ugh!!

Before he can finish the sentence, the frightened man suddenly realizes he can't move—his body is pinned to the floor.

He turns his head with difficulty, only to see a gun pressed against his partner's head.

???: W-Wait ...! We were only looking for medicine! We didn't mean any harm!

The red-haired woman tightens her grip on his wrist.

Marsha: Medicine? Who are you?

# [English text unavailable]

COL-312706

As Their Shield

Marsha presses a piece of gauze to the man's cheek. A cut from the rough wall she pushed him into.

Adelheid holsters her pistol and folds her arms, listening to the other man.

Mikhail: My name is Mikhail, and the man you're pinning against the wall is my comrade, Alexei.

Mikhail: We're from nearby—Dorovka.

Marsha: Are you soldiers?

Mikhail: Yes. We were in Brest when the armistice was signed. At first, they sent us back to recover at the hospital in town, but then things started to fall apart.

Mikhail: We've been looking through these old buildings for medical supplies—anything we could use to help the wounded there.

Mikhail: We thought maybe we could bring them back something before we got out of here. The hospital is really desperate for supplies.

Marsha: What happened to the hospital?

Mikhail glances between Marsha and Adelheid, and his eyes brighten when he notices the badge on Marsha's chest.

Mikhail: A few days ago, there was chatter that Manus Vindictae was launching an attack. But no one took it seriously; we thought they were on the run.

Mikhail: Then they hit us in force. In just a few days they overran what was left of the army and seized control of all the supply routes. Now they're squeezing the life out of every last pocket of resistance.

Mikhail: We know they'll hit Dorovka any day now. But there's no way to evacuate the wounded safely.

Mikhail: Ma'am, you're from the St. Pavlov Foundation, aren't you? I recognized your badge.

Mikhail's pleading gaze on Marsha says what he cannot.

Marsha: That's correct. Mikhail, do you know how many people are still in the hospital?

Mikhail: About a hundred. Mostly the wounded that are too weak to move, along with the doctors and nurses.

Mikhail: What will happen if Manus Vindictae surrounds the hospital ...?

The scenario plays out in Marsha's mind to its inevitable end.

Marsha: I will contact the Foundation in Sen, explain the situation, and request immediate support.

Marsha: But they won't have time to get here before the Manus. Before then ...

Marsha looks at Adelheid. Her head has dipped, heavy with thoughts of her own.

Marsha: Mikhail, I need to discuss this with my comrade.

Marsha: If possible, I will join you at the hospital and do what I can to assist you until the Foundation arrives.

Mikhail: Thank you!

Behind them, Adelheid has opened the door and briskly stepped outside.

Outside the house, Adelheid removes the little shield hanging at her waist.

Thin sheet metal with a rough weld. Never properly polished, its uneven edges sting her palms as she turns it in her hand.

Adelheid: By this time tomorrow, we may have reclaimed our stolen relics. All the wealth and history of our Order lies just out of grasp.

The thin morning light turns the distant horizon pale.

Marsha: ... By this time tomorrow, that hospital, and all of the people inside, may be nothing more than a charred ruin.

Marsha: These people need our help.

Adelheid frowns, yet her eyes can't help tracing the simple strokes painted across the shield.

Staś had never seen their home. He had no idea what Hohes Schloss actually looked like.

But through Adelheid's words, it seems he imagined it as an unyielding tower that stood tall atop a mountain for a thousand years.

A castle where generations of knights lived, fighting for justice in service of the weak and the needy.

The place she had left before coming to Sen, where she had met a boy in need of help. The boy who painted this tall and noble tower.

Adelheid: Losing those relics has laid our shame bare to the whole world.

Adelheid: As Acting Grand Master, I failed to stop them; I was derelict in my most sacred duty.

Adelheid: Now I have a chance to right this injustice. I cannot allow them to escape.

Adelheid: If the Order is to survive, we must reclaim those priceless treasures.

Adelheid looks down the road toward the town center, conflict tightening her expression.

Marsha: "You shall be the shield that protects the weak."

Adelheid replies with a dry, bitter laugh.

Adelheid: We always recite the words from The Code of Chivalry and the Knight's Vows before we march.

Adelheid: Whether to defend a knight's honor or save precious lives ... Such things ought not to be weighed against one another.

Adelheid: Yet, here we are, forced to decide.

Marsha walks up to her mentor and comrade-in-arms.

Marsha: Remind me, Sister Adelheid, why did you receive this shield?

She replies with a sharp glance deep with turmoil.

Adelheid: A boy lingered in death's hand, sick with a deadly fever. But I cured him. In turn, I suppose he wanted to protect me.

Marsha: It may not be the equal of our greatest relics. But it was given with noble intention.

Neither need say the obvious. A bullet would pass through that thin sheet metal like it was paper.

But Adelheid planned to carry it into battle all the same.

Marsha: Our vows have always been in service to people like him. Without expectation of reward.

Marsha: That single act of mercy is more worthy of our vows than a thousand gilded relics and chests of looted gold. That shield is proof of your honor as a knight.

Marsha: I don't see a dilemma at all.

Marsha's voice is as soft as rustling grass. She knows she's challenging everything her mentor has ever held dear, but she will not let it go unsaid.

Adelheid: ... If we miss this opportunity, there may never be another chance to reclaim what we've lost.

Marsha: But the Order has a long way ahead—

Marsha: Long enough for us to restore its glory and fill that emptied castle once more.

Marsha: Let it begin with that rusty shield. Let it be the sign of what it is to be a "true knight."

Marsha stands firm. She can sense her old master hesitating; all she needs is a gentle push.

Yet for as much as it might herald a new beginning, that tower on her shield is also a reminder of their roots.

Adelheid: ... I remember when you were the one that couldn't wait to face the enemy. Leaping to your death instead of falling back to care for the wounded.

Marsha smiles softly.

Marsha: War changes us. It changes everything. In ways that cannot be undone. But I must believe the changes I went through have a purpose.

Adelheid: ... With two Hochland Knights in their defense, the hospital may just hold out until the Foundation's support arrives.

Marsha exhales in relief.

Marsha: Thank you, Adelheid.

She smiles and then takes out her communicator.

Marsha: Mr. Razor, we have an emergency ...

Adelheid gives the shield one last glance before fastening it back to her waist.

Combat Hospital, Dorovka

The four of them waste no time and reach Dorovka by noon. They can spy the hospital from the end of the road.

But something else comes into view as well—rising smoke.

Alexei: Damn it! They're already here—

Marsha: Wait, Alexei!

Marsha grabs the soldier just before he begins to charge. She fixes her focus on the distant scene.

Marsha: The smoke isn't coming from the hospital. It's ringing outside. They're still fighting.

Marsha: Hmm? What's that ...

In the bright flare of exploding grenades, hardened steel flashes silver, and horses pant and whinny as they pound across the concrete.

Adelheid: That can only be the Order. They're here, and they're fighting Manus Vindictae.

Adelheid's voice lifts with each word.

Marsha: Then there were other knights nearby ...

After the initial shock, Marsha nearly cries out in joy and relief.

Marsha: Hurry—let's move!

She releases Alexei as they all begin to dash forward toward the battle.

Adelheid follows a few steps behind. She can see Marsha from the back.

All of a sudden, it seems as if she were that foolhardy girl once more.

But then the wind lifts the edge of her grayish green coat, revealing a glimpse of the nurse's uniform beneath.

The unexpected arrival of a dozen knights of the Hochland Order catches the splinter force of Manus Vindictae completely off-guard.

Outside the hospital, the knights mop up, ensuring the threat is completely neutralized.

Marsha: The hospital is safe; we've run the Manus off for now, thanks to the Hochland Order.

Marsha: I need to speak with the head of the hospital and assess our situation.

"Razor" Captain: Your requested reinforcements are still enroute, even if Manus aren't a threat for now, that hospital needs to be evacuated.

Marsha: Understood.

Just as Marsha finishes her report, she is suddenly pulled into a warm, excited embrace.

Hildegard: My dear Marsha, you're alive!

A familiar face brightens on her like a golden sun; her childhood sparring partner leaps toward her with a beaming smile.

Marsha hugs her back just as tightly.

Marsha: Yes, Hilde, I'm alive.

Marsha: I'm so glad we found you here! But why are you here?

Hildegard: We weren't supposed to come this way, but we heard from some of the evacuees that the hospital was in trouble. We rode as fast as we could; God be good, we made it in time.

Hildegard: And on top of that, to find you and Master Adelheid together. It is truly a blessed day, sister.

Adelheid: ...

Adelheid does not interrupt the reunion between comrades.

She listens to Hildegard as the victorious warrior beams with yet more words of joy and knightly elan, drifting deep into thought.

# [English text unavailable]

COL-312708

Analgesic Method

Hallway, Combat Hospital

Although Manus Vindictae has been driven off, the battle has only worsened the hospital's condition.

Its corridors, already crowded, have received a new influx of wounded. Coughs and low groans echo out even past the doors.

What knights and soldiers can stand help move the wounded through the hallway and into the makeshift triage.

Wounded Soldier: We have to go! We're all going to die!

A soldier on one of the beds suddenly thrashes upright, shoving away the nurse who is trying to stymie his bleeding.

The nurse grips his shoulder to steady him.

Another doctor rushes over with several strips of cloth, trying to tie the soldier's arm to the side of the bed.

But he only struggles harder.

Nurse: Doctor, he needs a sedative.

Doctor: No! His pulse is too weak. Someone hold him down—

Just then a hand covered in armor reaches in and presses gently on the soldier's forehead.

Nurse: Sister Marsha!

In short order Marsha has made herself indispensable to the staff here as they treat the wounded and dying as best as they can.

Marsha: I've used my arcane skill to calm his delirium. You should be able to treat him now.

She moves between wards. Her pale face running damp with sweat.

Doctor: Phew ... Sister, you arrived just in time.

On the bed, the soldier's murmuring softens, and his movements slow. The doctor quickly binds his limbs and begins stitching the wound.

Mikhail: Sister Marsha!

Marsha turns and sees Mikhail at the doorway, accompanied by a woman in a nun's uniform.

Marsha checks the soldier for a moment more. When the doctor gives her a nod, she steps toward the door.

Irene: I am Mother Superior Irene, and you must be the woman from the Foundation.

She takes hold of Marsha's hands in a firm but gentle grasp.

Irene: God bless you for what you've done here!

Marsha: I've done very little, Reverend Mother. The knights of the Hochland Order arrived before we did.

Marsha: But more support from the Foundation is on the way. They should arrive before nightfall.

Irene: Any help they can provide is already a miracle. There are still so many wounded here; these young men need all the help we can give them.

She looks around the hospital, her expression heavy with grief.

Irene: We had hoped that there would finally be an end to this bloodshed after the armistice. But it seems the war continues, just wearing a different face.

Irene: With the rumors of bandits and violence further east, everyone is worried for their families. But they want to help; they want to bring an end to this violence.

Marsha: I will see about securing their passage home, Reverend Mother. I'm certain the Foundation will appreciate whatever help they can offer.

The nun thanks Marsha once again, even more effusively than the last time.

Nurse II: Mother Irene—

A panting nurse rushes down the hallway, holding an empty glass bottle.

Nurse II: We're out of ether. There's only one bottle left in the warehouse.

More bad news arrives, and the dutiful woman responds.

She must weigh the value of each resource against the lives and suffering around her.

Irene: Prioritize surgeries; we need to make this bottle last until the evening.

Irene: For the others, we'll have to rely on pressure and immobilization. Have we any alcohol left?

The nurse nods.

Irene: A shame it's all ethyl; more than anything, I think these boys need a stiff drink. But in lieu of that, soak some herbs with it and use them as topical salves.

She turns to Marsha.

Irene: Sister, would you mind relaying the urgency of our situation to the Foundation once more?

Marsha: Of course.

Marsha looks around the room and sees other knights in silver armor working through their injuries and pain to assist the beleaguered hospital staff.

She tightens her trembling hand, then makes a resolute decision.

Marsha: Reverend Mother, perhaps there's something more I can do.

# [English text unavailable]

COL-312709

Early in the morning, Adelheid moves through the hospital, searching for someone.

Adelheid: Sister Hildegard, have you seen Marsha?

Hildegard pauses at the question. She's been boarding up doors and windows since the evening prior.

Hildegard: I passed by her about a half hour ago; she was coming out of the operating room. Why?

Adelheid: I haven't been able to find her.

Adelheid: What was she doing in an operating room?

Nurse III: Oh! I can explain.

A nearby nurse pushes a medicine cabinet as a brace against the door and joins the conversation.

Nurse III: After we ran out of anesthetic last night, Sister Marsha offered to use her arcane skill to help the men through their surgeries.

Nurse III: Last I saw her, she was headed to the storage room.

Adelheid exchanges a knowing look with Hildegard, her eyebrows knit tightly.

Adelheid: Do you have any ice, nurse? We need a bucketful or more.

Nurse III: Nothing we can spare here, no. But some of the soldiers found an ice room in the cellar of an old building nearby.

Nurse III: It was quite large; I think perhaps it was for a restaurant. We've been sending parties to collect ice from it from time to time, but there should still be plenty left.

Nurse III: But what do you need the ice for?

Adelheid: Worry not, we'll take care of it.

Adelheid: Hildegard, fetch that ice and bring it to the storage room—now.

Adelheid: That foolhardy girl. She's pushed herself far beyond her limits; I'm certain of it.

Adelheid: I doubt she can even move for all the pain she's taken in.

As Adelheid enters the storage room, her suspicions are immediately confirmed by the slow, ragged breaths that heave out from the corner.

Marsha: *painful exhale* Urgh—

In a room of empty boxes, old sheets, and broken things, she finds Marsha curled up against the wall. Her eyes are shut; tears and sweat form a confluence of rivers as they pour down her cheeks and neck.

Adelheid: Marsha!

Adelheid hurries to her side and eases her gently to the floor.

At just a touch, she can feel the burning heat radiating from her body.

Marsha: Adelheid, ugh—

Adelheid: Shh. Don't speak. Slow your breathing ... there's nothing for it now. You must simply endure.

Adelheid: Hildegard is bringing up some ice water. We'll cool you down just like we used to back home; do you remember that?

Adelheid: I know you've always feared the cold; you have every reason, but you won't survive this heat.

Marsha gives a small nod, forcing a faint, apologetic smile.

Adelheid: You just won't be content until you die a martyr, will you?

Adelheid: Why would you do something so reckless? Every time you take in someone else's pain, you put your own life at risk.

Marsha: I know ... But, I have you ...

Marsha gasps the words out between heaves, her voice weak.

Adelheid is struck in waves: concern, then fury, pity, and lastly, pride.

Had there been no other knights in the hospital, Marsha might have looked for other options.

But she knew the others would understand what she'd done and what to do.

It wasn't reckless; it was a calculated risk. An act of complete trust in her comrades-in-arms.

Adelheid: ... Promise me, Marsha. Swear by your oath you will never do this to me again.

Hildegard: Marsha!

The other knights arrive hauling a tub and buckets of ice water, barking orders back and forth as they clear a space in the crowded room.

Together they lift Marsha up and ease her into icy water.

Marsha: Mmph!

Burning heat hits icy cold; the clash is severe, sharp, painful, sending her into convulsing shivers as she sinks into the tub.

Words fail to breach through her now-clattering teeth. Hot and cold slam into one another like the beginning of a cyclone; the pain swirls in her, tearing her thoughts apart. Her vision darkens.

Adelheid: Marsha!

She falls back into the abyss.

# [English text unavailable]

COL-312710

The Eagle and the Firewood

# [English text unavailable]

COL-312711

Marsha: Hyah!

Marsha: Hurry now, Freya!

The Sachsen lifts its hooves and charges into the fierce Alpine wind.

Above them an eagle flies, its broad and powerful wings cutting through the sky like a golden arrow.

Marsha: Look, above us! It's wonderful to see Verena flying so high after her recovery ...

Marsha gazes at the soaring raptor. Her young face lit with excitement.

She had found the injured eaglet beneath a mountain ridge a month ago and took it under her care.

Now, as if a gift in honor of her eighteenth birthday, her charge once again takes flight.

A good omen, she hopes, for her own ceremony. With the swearing of her sacred vows to the Order, on this day, dressed in her finest robes, she will become a true knight.

Marsha: Today, Freya, I become a knight of the Order. Sworn to fight in its honor. I submitted an application too; if the Grand Master accepts, I'll be trained as a pilot!

She leans down to share her secret dream with the horse as they ride forward.

Marsha: Then I'll fly through the air, just like Verena.

Marsha: I can't even imagine what it must be like to see the world from above. They say that once you're high enough, the whole world just looks like moss growing over a rock.

The young novice spurs her horse, giving chase to the triumphant eagle. She is about to become a knight and soon a pilot flying over the field of battle.

With the wind whipping past her ears, she feels as if she is already flying, riding the wind through fire and blood toward her future glory.

Marsha: Up there in the sky, skill and courage alone decide victory and defeat, just like jousting knights in the old days.

Marsha: Up there, she can bring victory and honor to her Order and her nation!

She loses herself in the vision. In her mind, she imagines herself as her eagle, looking down at the world as she swoops between the clouds.

The boundary between earth and sky dissolves. Her dream feels close enough to touch.

Marsha: Faster, Freya! We have to keep up—

The horse answers with a loud neigh. It sounds like an agreement. She races wherever the knight's heart leads them, swift as a flash. No field is too vast for them.

Glory. Bravery. Loyalty. These are virtues and the triumphs of a knight.

Galloping hard, Marsha believes her path lies wherever these words guide her.

At last, the eagle becomes no more than a gray speck on the horizon. And Marsha allows her steed to slow and rest. Her dream flies off on the back of those golden wings until—

Adelheid: There you are, Marsha.

Marsha snaps out of her reverie. She dismounts in a flash and rushes toward her teacher.

Marsha: Adelheid! Did the reply come? Did the Grand Master approve my application?

Adelheid sighs.

Adelheid: I'm sorry, Marsha, but you've been assigned to the 15th Infantry Regiment. You depart in one week.

Adelheid grips Marsha's shoulder firmly, trying to temper her young novice's enthusiasm with a serious look.

Adelheid: There's nothing romantic about the war you're about to face, child. You must be ready to take care of yourself.

At the time, Marsha couldn't fully understand the gravity of her mentor's words.

Though she did not get to live out her dream, she was still excited to serve her Order.

Able to finally march out and win glory as a knight.

Combat Hospital, Dorovka

Marsha wakes with a deep ache in her bones. Her heartbeat drums in her ears.

The ice water has done its job, easing the worst of her pain.

She lies on a makeshift "bed" of sheets, her clothes already dry.

Marsha: I need to thank Adelheid properly.

She sits up, and the first thing that meets her eyes is a pair of hands.

The nails are uneven. Thick calluses cover the joints. The dry skin is cracked, and bronze stains linger around the fingertips.

They are the hardened hands of a trained knight, reshaped by disinfectant and iodine.

Wounded Soldier: Ugh!

Doctor: Who can check on Iliia? His wound may be infected!

Marsha steps out of the storage room.

Marsha: I have Dakin's solution here!

Marsha returns to her work as though nothing had ever happened.

Though the words of her mentor linger in the back of her mind.

Marsha: Let me clean this wound.

She returns to the patients and leaves her past behind.

The stars and the moon hang in the sky once more, but there's still no sign of reinforcements or relief as Marsha calls to make her report.

Marsha: ... Sir, if possible, I hope the Foundation will be able to transfer the heavily wounded to safer territory.

Creius: I will speak with "Razor" and leave the matter to him.

Marsha: Mr. Razor was supposed to meet me in town this evening, but I haven't been able to reach him.

Creius: I received a report that he made contact with Manus Vindictae along the way. But as soon as he mops up that little problem, he should arrive at the hospital without delay.

Marsha allows herself to relax, tense aching muscles finally slack. Though the change would be imperceptible to most.

Marsha: Good. Then I will await his arrival.

Marsha: There are some soldiers here from out east, the Don region. They've heard about the fighting there and wanted to help. Could transportation be arranged?

Marsha: Also, I've submitted a request to remain here and assist the hospital staff until the evacuation is complete.

Creius: Approved and arranged. Though I expect you to accompany them on their journey back.

Creius: The Timekeeper's team will be headed that way as well.

Creius: Your next mission is to support our Zeno allies in their fight and to rendezvous with the Timekeeper's team to assist them in whatever they need.

Marsha: Understood, sir.

Creius: Hold on, soldier. Mind if I ask about your friends from the Order?

Marsha: They'll be staying behind here as well for the time being. We're working together to get the wounded treated and evacuated safely.

Creius: Right. Here's hoping this will mark a change in our rocky relationship. Keep me updated.

Marsha: Yes, sir.

Hildegard: Marsha!

Марша: Marsha hears someone calling her name.

Not far away, several knights sit together in a loose circle, soft laughter drifting from the group. Hildegard waves at her.

Hildegard: Feeling better?

Marsha: Yes. I'm sorry for making you worry.

Hildegard waves her hand.

Hildegard: I'm just glad Adelheid found you when she did. I'm not sure if you would have lasted much longer.

Marsha sits down beside her.

Marsha: What were you talking about?

Hildegard: Old memories. Remembering all the chores we had to do when we were novices.

Under the night sky, the knights' faces light up as they reminisce.

Marsha: Ah, I remember—carrying up those bundles of firewood that were nearly as tall as we were.

Hildegard: Yeah. And it wasn't even our job most of the time!

Not every would-be knight had a pure heart. Some of the older novices would often slack off and bully the younger kids into doing their work.

Hildegard: All the way up the hill, three or four of us at a time. And the bundles would never hold together.

Hildegard: I remember we'd try to chase the ones that fell out as they rolled off the side, tumbling into the woods.

The two young novices would simply sit at the edge of the slope and sigh.

Marsha: I always loved the stories you told about them.

Marsha: Those falling pieces were actually adventurous wood sprites we had freed from their roots, and now they were travelling to distant lands.

Marsha: They would talk to the wind, do battle with legions of insects and beasts, float along rivers, and eventually rest on a shore, waiting for a new journey to begin.

Hildegard: Haha. What can I say? I've always enjoyed a "knightly adventure."

They laugh together like old friends, like sisters.

Under the hospital eaves, the branches in the courtyard act as silent witnesses, holding on to their memories. A breeze passes through, and those memories drift away bit by bit into the night.

Hildegard: I miss those days so much, Marsha, when even the most trivial of things carried an unquestioned meaning.

Hildegard: Things felt as though they were in perfect order. Every bundle of wood had its purpose. Even if it was only meant to warm a study room.

It should be as simple as that. Knights that set out to fight for justice and wander the land … returning laden with treasures and glory.

This was the story they wanted for themselves. Back then they couldn't or wouldn't imagine any other end.

Marsha: … Have you spoken to the Grand Master?

Hildegard: I have. We're all concerned with what we should do next.

Hildegard: Marsha, you've found your own path, haven't you?

There's a trace of envy in her eyes as she says it.

Marsha: You know, Hilde? Ever since I met Adelheid again, I've started dreaming of the old days.

Marsha opens her hand, as if turning the pages of a book.

Marsha: Dreams that have let me relive my past, the good and the bad.

Marsha: One thing is certain—Though I've traveled far, I never strayed from the right path.

Marsha: Seeing things here, I think that's true of the Knights of Hochland as well.

Marsha glances around at the end of her words.

Marsha: Hilde, where is Adelheid?

# [English text unavailable]

COL-312712

The Burden of Glory

Outside, Combat Hospital

Marsha finds the knight a short walk from the hospital, sitting in quiet contemplation at the edge of a field. She sits down near her without intruding.

The knight sits among the bending tall grass like an old stone. As if she had always been there.

Adelheid: To sit in silence and set the mind to quiet is an essential virtue for a knight. In contemplation we may search our resolve and explore the depths of our belief.

It was a lecture she had heard before, and the message was clear. So, for some time longer they sit together in silence, accompanied only by the rustle of the autumn wind.

Adelheid: With our training, we can sometimes forget that we do need to use arcane skills to quiet our emotion. Sometimes, it is better to do battle with the trouble in our hearts instead of pushing it away.

Marsha: What is it that you're fighting, Adelheid?

Adelheid: Regret.

Adelheid: When I saw our knights outside the hospital, I was relieved, overjoyed to have found some of our lost comrades. But though we saved these people, we left Rejowa; we let Manus slip through our hands.

Marsha: ...

Adelheid: I cannot find a center between my joy and my despair. Now the path ahead for our Order seems more unclear than ever before.

Marsha: You made the right decision based on what we knew.

Adelheid: I did. And I am greatly heartened to have found Hildegard and the others. That is itself a blessing.

Adelheid: But they did not come here for me. I didn't know they were here. I didn't even know they were alive. Our order has no home and no direction. It has only magnified my disgrace.

Marsha: I know the burdens of command weigh heavy on you, Sister. But you must not be so harsh on yourself. You were given responsibility for an organization that was already falling to ruin; its troubles are not of your making.

Adelheid: ... There is a little solace in that.

Adelheid: But though I may not have created these troubles, I have been a steward over them and stubbornly refused to fix them.

Adelheid: And I think I found the reason. I am in search of an answer, not just for the Order, but for my own sake.

Adelheid: Who is responsible for the Order's downfall?

A cruel question.

Adelheid: Manus Vindictae? That answer is too easy—to blame an enemy for our downfall is a hollow excuse.

Adelheid: Shall I blame the Kaiser? The military? The state? How long have we served the rulers of this land and never once doubted their authority?

Adelheid: But I fear the truth is all too simple ... The Order has grown outdated. The Age of Chivalry is long over; we've always been a mere remnant. The horrors of this war come as a long-awaited death knell.

Marsha: But ...

Adelheid raises her hand, stopping Marsha.

Adelheid: When I found you in that storage room, I was filled with guilt and regret ...

Adelheid: I felt the same way the day I heard of your "death."

Adelheid: I will never regret saving you from that snow, child. But perhaps I was wrong to bring you to the Order.

Adelheid: You could have lived some happy life with a normal family ... instead we forced you to suppress your nature, molded you into a warrior, and convinced you that it was your duty to give your life for the sake of your vows.

A silent grief strikes Marsha's heart. Adelheid has carried her "death" all this time.

Marsha: I'm sorry I didn't tell you then. I shouldn't have let you carry that guilt.

Marsha: I don't regret becoming a knight, Adelheid. My days with the Order have given me the most precious gift.

Marsha: It is the character you, Adelheid and the Order gave to me that has kept me from despair in the face of horror. It is my vows that keep me on my path when the way is narrow and the road uneasy.

Marsha turns to Adelheid, closing in toward her, meeting her face. Adelheid replies with a defeated sigh.

Adelheid: I can see your resolve.

Adelheid: Once we brought your temperature down, I left to help the others.

Adelheid: I feel as though I looked away only a moment before you were right back up, tending to the wounded as if you had forgotten you had nearly died.

Adelheid: You may only have the pauldrons now. But you are as true a knight as any of us.

Adelheid: A worthy sister of the Hochland Order.

Adelheid returns briefly to her contemplation, picturing the knights working tirelessly through the hospital, and Marsha stands among them.

Adelheid: So, I say to myself—

Adelheid: See, Adelheid. Chivalry has not faded after all. It can still be a shield that protects the weak and vulnerable of this age.

Adelheid turns to meet Marsha's eyes. Conviction and pride burning on her face.

Adelheid: As for the proposal you mentioned, this reimagining of the Order ... I will consider it.

Hallway, Combat Hospital

In the soft golden light of dawn, a transport convoy bearing the Foundation's logo arrives outside the hospital.

Marsha finishes up her rotation through the ward. But on hearing the noise, she finds an unboarded window and leans out to get a view.

Marsha: Mr. Razor, good to see you've finally arrived.

The squad captain offers her a wordless nod before returning to unloading the vehicle.

Behind him, people in gray-and-white checkered uniforms carry supplies into the hospital as new medics rush in beside them.

Marsha: Reverend Mother, this is Mr. Razor from the Foundation.

Marsha leads Irene over.

Irene: Mr. Razor, we appreciate the Foundation's support. Your arrival is a long-awaited godsend.

"Razor" Captain: Don't mention it. We've got our orders. We'll begin by transferring all the heavily wounded out to a safer location.

"Razor" Captain: In four days' time, there'll be a train passing through the station nearby. Everyone else is to load up there for evacuation.

Marsha: I've been given permission to remain with you here until that time. And once we evacuate, I will be accompanying the soldiers that wish to keep fighting in the Don region.

Marsha: We'll be deployed to assist the Zeno Cavalry Corps near Bereggrad.

Irene: Wonderful. I'll share the good news immediately.

After Irene leaves, "Razor" turns back to Marsha.

"Razor" Captain: I should apologize. We've arrived much later than intended. I'm not proud of that.

Marsha: I understand. Mr. Creius informed me of the situation; you were delayed by Manus Vindictae.

"Razor" Captain: We ran into one of their own convoys along the way. It was heavily defended. But what they were transporting might just be of interest to you.

Marsha's heart skips a beat.

Marsha: Do you mean ...?

"Razor" Captain: You should gather the knights first.

Marsha summons her brothers and sisters, and they follow "Razor" out to the Foundation's parked convoy. Among the familiar liveries of the Foundation, one truck stands apart.

Marsha: A Manus truck.

"Razor" Captain: Correct. We had already gotten word that the hospital was secure. So, we knew we had an opportunity.

"Razor" Captain: We decided to engage them, just to see what was worth all of the fuss they put into defending it.

"Razor" Captain: We sent them packing and managed to seize the transports they were protecting. Which led us to this one.

"Razor" Captain: During the inventory we noticed that many of the items bore the seal of your Order, Marsha. So, the Foundation authorized us to return these spoils to the Hochland Order.

Adelheid: ...!

Adelheid steps forward in disbelief as "Razor" opens the door of the truck.

Inside the dim interior lie dozens of covered paintings, stacks upon stacks of yellowed books and tomes, silverware, and a shattered, dust-covered sword.

Adelheid: The ledger of the Hochland Order. Candlesticks from the meeting hall, and ...

A sword forged of patterned steel rests among them. Its hilt is wrapped in black horsehide; the blade fractured into several pieces.

The familiar Latin inscription can still be made out along the broken blade.

Adelheid: That's Hermann's sword, the one that vanished after his death.

Adelheid gathers the broken blade into her arms. Her finger runs along the edge lightly, and a thin line of blood wells up. A dim, dark-blue shimmer ripples across the sword.

Adelheid: Hermann's arcane skill, bound to the blade and awakened by blood, reveals the truth.

Adelheid: Hermann used this sword in his fight with Manus Vindictae, leaving traces of their incantations on it.

Adelheid: They must have taken it to hide any evidence of their involvement.

A long-rumored secret finally lays itself bare.

Behind Adelheid, the knights drive their swords into the earth, hands resting on the hilts, heads bowed in silence.

Marsha puts her hands together and offers a quiet prayer for her old Grand Master.

"Razor" Captain: We didn't recognize the sword at first, but we found the Order's name on some of those books and documents. Though we knew for sure after we saw this ...

"Razor" pulls away the velvet cloth covering the paintings.

After the dust settles, the solemn and sacred past appears on display in front of them.

Marsha: ...!

Hildegard: That's Marsha's dubbing ceremony!

Hildegard: I remember we had a painter staying with us at the castle; he painted the ceremony to repay us for our hospitality.

Hildegard: That was the day Marsha took her vows as a knight.

To have such a moment memorialized in a painting is a rare honor.

Yet by coincidence, Marsha's knighting was preserved forever.

A moment that belonged not just to her but to all the knights of her Order.

Every knight once stood in that same place during the dubbing ceremony. They pledged vows before their new brothers and sisters and waited for the sword, the very symbol of knighthood, to rest on their shoulders.

Marsha: I vow to hold the Hochland Order in reverence, to defend it faithfully ...

Marsha: I vow to keep this oath without deceit, to heed the statutes of virtue, and to honor the counsel of my brethren—

Marsha: Until the day of my death.

Marsha murmurs her oaths beneath her breath, flooded by the memory.

Marsha: ... All the training I've done was in service of that day.

Marsha: The day I became a "knight."

In the painting, Marsha's expression is solemn. She wears her ceremonial attire. Her folded hands tell of her expectation for the glory to come.

Countless faces of knights, living and fallen, seem as though they could perfectly overlap with the girl's face.

Hildegard: The knights departed from Hohes Schloss after the dubbing ceremony, carrying out their duties under the Grand Master's command.

Hildegard: We looked ahead to future missions, eager to prove ourselves, to return with glory earned by our swords.

Until that "knightly glory" was laid to waste beneath the withering scythe of machine gun fire. Now, the ones that survive wander without purpose around its grave.

But the young woman in that painting walks a different path—a narrow one, defined by her vows but no longer constrained to them.

A path too small for steeds to charge, too tight for armor to pass. So, she releases her horse, lays down her sword, and packs away her breastplate.

Yet she keeps her pauldrons. Their silvery steel gleams as a guide, like the North Star, a reminder of what matters.

Adelheid: ... The Knights of Hochland must begin anew.

As the painting is uncovered, the distance between past and present clears away the dust of history. It opens a bloody wound long left untended. A rift that has kept them divided and weak.

Adelheid removes her cloak and gently covers the broken sword.

Adelheid: I never would have dared to dream this sword could be recovered.

Stranger still for it to have been found and returned by an organization she had long distrusted.

Adelheid: Though the sword is far from our Order's most precious relic. It's possible all of the items of true value are gone forever. Heh ... But it doesn't matter.

The painting before them once proudly adorned their home's stone corridor.

The candlesticks once burned in the meeting hall, witnessing the knights' worship and prayer.

Apart from that sword, the rest of the items are humble things from the castle.

Yet though they may be of little worth, they are rich in memories. Not all of them glorious, but small, tangible, and real.

Adelheid: Even so ... I feel our treasure has been restored.

Just like the shield Staś gave to Adelheid, the one she carries at her waist.

Adelheid: What defines a knight?

Adelheid asks herself.

Adelheid: ... To uphold our values and never bow to evil, to honor our brethren alive and dead through our words and our deeds.

Marsha: "It is more of a heavy burden than an honor." You told me that after the dubbing ceremony.

Marsha walks up to her mentor and comrade-in-arms.

Adelheid: Yes. A knight's path is not one of extravagance and luxury. We learn to endure hardship and live simply. To keep our minds fixed on justice.

Adelheid looks deep into Marsha's eyes. The future knighthood in her vision stands right beside her.

The answer is within reach.

Adelheid turns and faces the others.

Adelheid: Brothers and sisters. After we leave this hospital, we will search for our scattered comrades.

Adelheid: Along the way, I intend to follow Sister Marsha's advice. This age does not need mounted warriors, but it still needs the Order. We will find a new purpose: to help the vulnerable, to heal the sick, and to care for the wounded as we once did in days of old.

Adelheid: The knights will distance themselves from the wicked games of war. We shall return to where we first began.

Adelheid: From this day on, we fight only to save lives—from the sickle of death.

Adelheid: Our efforts will no longer be confined by nationality or creed.

A murmur ripples through the knights, yet not a single voice rises in opposition.

Marsha listens quietly, surprised.

Hildegard: We will follow wherever you lead, Adelheid, but this is a significant change ...

Adelheid: That may be so. I am but the acting Grand Master, though it is my vision. I will convene a meeting of the Order so that we might decide on our path together.

Adelheid looks at "Razor."

Adelheid: If the Order chooses this path, there may come a day when we will seek to collaborate with the Foundation—provided the Foundation remains what it is today.

The squad leader bows his head in respectful agreement.

"Razor" Captain: May the peace be with us.

Adelheid: Sister Marsha, should that day come, I hope that you will be as you have been, a bridge between our organizations.

Marsha: I will, Grand Master.

The simple words are said as a solemn oath.

A breeze sweeps across the plains, carrying the crisp scent of late autumn frost. As it passes through them, it seems to strip away the dust that has gathered on their Order.

The morning light shines on them, a promise of a new day, a new beginning.

Marsha raises her hand before her eyes. The brilliant dawn spills in through her fingertips.

Marsha: Hmm ... what a good day it is.